

the feed. Persons interested in reading an article will click the link and visit the site.

Paradoxically, the same web marketing individuals will add social media plugins to every page in the website. Will that not cause the reader to leave the website? Apparently, that is okay. Don't you want your content to become viral? Unfortunately, this traffic is very fickle and will not even return. Easy come, easy go. Another important thing that web marketers ignore is that not every social media mention is seen by all followers. To limit information overload and to monetise traffic leaving to external sites, social media companies deliberately limit the visibility of users' posts. In other words, subtle censorship. To gain visibility, they want you to advertise. In other words, subtle extortion. The sites that advertise get more visibility. You have to pay money to one guy to bring in traffic and then make money from another who displays ads. The gamble may not pay off.

In contrast, the anonymous RSS costs almost nothing extra. Growth of this organic traffic may be linear and slow. Over time however, the publisher can reap the benefits of an ever-growing audience that no middleman can censor. Publishers must foster this kind of loyal traffic that is dependable. Social media traffic can dry up suddenly one day when they inexplicably change their algorithm (as they have done many times in the past) or if payments cannot be made.

Instead of diverting traffic to social media sites, publishers should ask visitors to subscribe to their RSS feeds. When a feed indicates that there is valuable content on a site, the subscribers will click and visit the site. When they visit the site, the publisher can then monetise the traffic by:

- Serving unobtrusive ads to the visitors, that is, no annoying overlays or pop-ups
- Provide easy links to subscribe to:
 - An ad-free paywall
 - A print edition

RSS is not the only game in town. Online publishers can use other mediums to monetise their content. Email newsletters are one of them. Some people prefer email newsletters as their email clients enable them to perform offline searches of news articles. The same headline, link, snippet, and intro image strategy used in RSS feeds can be used in email newsletters too. However, email is subject to filters and deliverability issues. You need to proceed with great care as irresponsible use of email newsletters can result in blacklisting of your domain. You can read more about this subject in my free ebook 'Email Newsletter Strategies For Profit'.

Anatomy of an RSS feed

An RSS feed is so simple that it can be hand-coded. Most website content management systems (CMS) and blogging software automatically generate RSS feeds.

The initial part of the XML is metadata about the feed. In this metadata, the RSS feed identifies itself and also provides a link back to itself. What follows next are individual news items or article metadata wrapped inside item tags. Each item tag includes a title (or headline) and a link for the news item, status update, article, or blog post. A GUID tag is required to provide a globally unique ID to make it easy for an RSS reader to uniquely identify the item in its database. It is common practice to use the URL of the news item as a GUID if it happens to be unique.

```
<?xml version="1.0"?>
<rss version="2.0">
  <channel>
    <title>Weather forecast for Palakkad</title>
    <description>Daily weather forecast provided by ISRO</description>
    <link>https://www.isro.gov/weather-forecast/palakkad.xml</link>

    <item>
      <title>Warm sunny weather</title>
      <description>Clear sky.</description>
      <link>https://www.isro.gov/weather-forecast/palakkad-2023-10-20.html</link>
      <guid>https://www.isro.gov/weather-forecast/palakkad-2023-10-20.html</guid>
      <pubDate>Sun, 20 Oct 2023 00:00:00 +0530</pubDate>
    </item>

    <item>
      <title>Possibility of rain</title>
      <description>It may or may not rain.</description>
      <link>https://www.isro.gov/weather-forecast/palakkad-2023-10-19.html</link>
      <guid>https://www.isro.gov/weather-forecast/palakkad-2023-10-19.html</guid>
      <pubDate>Sat, 19 Oct 2023 00:00:00 +0530</pubDate>
    </item>

    <item>
      <title>Stormy weather and lightning</title>
      <description>Fisherman are advised not to venture into the sea.</description>
      <link>https://www.isro.gov/weather-forecast/palakkad-2023-10-18.html</link>
      <guid>https://www.isro.gov/weather-forecast/palakkad-2023-10-18.html</guid>
      <pubDate>Fri, 18 Oct 2023 00:00:00 +0530</pubDate>
    </item>
  </channel>
</rss>
```